

The role of soft power in regional diplomacy

A case study of Chinese and Japanese influence in Southeast Asia.

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INTRODUCTION

“The pen is mightier than the sword.” While Edward Bulwer-Lytton may not have intended it, his words have become the ideal type of soft power.¹ Soft power, as defined by author Andrew Heywood, is “The ability to influence other actors by *persuading* them to follow or agree to norms and aspirations that produce the desired behaviour.”² Originally coined by Harvard professor Joseph Nye to discuss American preponderance in the post-Cold War era, the term can and has been applied to the understanding of power dynamics and foreign policies in numerous regions of the world, including the increasingly pertinent continent of Asia.

With the rise of Asia as a whole, two of the “great powers” of the region, China and Japan, have relied heavily on soft power in their relations with the South-eastern nations of the continent. Since its launch of the Belt and Road Initiative (BRI) in 2013, China has drawn global attention, a by-product of which has been speculation that it is working against Japan to establish predominance in Southeast Asia. With two distinct, yet competing strategies, the struggle for supremacy in the region needs to be understood through a comparison of factors and implications of the two nations’ soft power strategies. Therefore, this essay will explore: **“How do China and Japan's soft power strategies in Southeast Asia differ?”**

LITERATURE REVIEW

Existing literature on the topic can be divided into two sections, one that is theoretically focused on the concept of soft power, and the other that discusses its use by China and Japan (some authors analysing their strategies specific to Southeast Asia).

The former selection of literature is largely focused on defining and concretising the abstract concept of soft power. Over time, the original definition of soft power as proposed by Joseph Nye has been challenged for being too narrow. Authors such as Jing Sun lament that soft power is too often considered “nice” power which reduces an understanding of its impact by suggesting a certain weakness in its use and effectiveness.³ The argument stands that successful

¹ Hendrik W Ohnesorge, *Soft Power – The forces of attraction in international relations* (Basel: Springer International Publishing, 2019)

² Andrew Heywood, *Global Politics* (London: Palgrave Macmillan, 2011)

³ Sun, Jing, *Japan and China as Charm Rivals: Soft Power in Regional Diplomacy* (University of Michigan, 2012)

persuasion, as cited in Heywood's definition, can also arise from strategies that make deliberate use of powerful, tangible resources to actively convince actors of a certain action.

Theoretical analyses are also laden with frameworks for the categorisation and classification of soft power, a variety of which have common elements. This attempt to form an objective and concrete analysis of this otherwise abstract concept is often unnecessarily diverse and requires much synthesis within the academic world. Nevertheless, works such as Hendrik W. Ohnesorge's "Soft Power- The Forces of Attraction in International Relations" provide a comprehensive structure that allows an understanding of soft power in terms of its sources (resources), methods of implementation (instruments), impact (reception) and effectiveness (outcomes).⁴

Works that discuss soft power in the context of China and Japan, such as Heng, Yee-Kuang's "Three Faces of Japan's Soft Power"⁵, often place the two countries as competitors within the same political arena of Southeast Asia and highlight the prominent differences in their approaches to soft power. This essay will therefore further these ideas in the context of the aforementioned theoretical frameworks.

SCOPE AND METHODOLOGY

To better understand the question at hand, this essay utilises a combination of both secondary and primary resources. While theoretical secondary resources have already been outlined in the previous section, these works were supplemented by news articles and opinion editorials by well-known sources such as E-International Relations and The Foreign Policy magazine. These allowed the collection of recent information that is yet to be analysed and published by scholars. Furthermore, primary sources such as Japan's release of its National security Strategy in December 2013⁶ also allowed a better understanding of the practical implementation of soft power strategies.

Due to the spatial limits of this paper, the essay will be limited to an investigation of the soft power strategies and policies of the governments of China and Japan. Therefore, cultural

⁴ Hendrik W Ohnesorge, *Soft Power – The forces of attraction in international relations* (Basel: Springer International Publishing, 2019)

⁵ Heng, Yee-Kuang, *Three Faces of Japan's Soft Power*. (Brill, 2017)

⁶ "National Security Strategy December 17, 2013 I. Purpose."
<https://www.cas.go.jp/jp/siryou/131217anzenhoshou/nss-e.pdf>.

aspects of soft power will only be explored within this context and will not be considered for their impacts outside the realm of official state action. As justified by author Jing Sun, it is important to “highlight the role of statist actors in creating soft power ... how governments and leaders seek to protect and enhance national interests through soft diplomatic mechanisms.”⁷

In his work, “Japan and China as Charm Rivals: Soft Power in Regional Diplomacy”, Jing Sun also mentions the key concept of “recipient context”,⁸ which seeks to prioritise the context and situation of those that are being influenced in understanding the reasons behind their reaction to and thus the effectiveness of certain soft power strategies. Unfortunately, as the focus of this essay is to inspect the differences in the design of China and Japan’s strategies themselves, an exploration of their reception by Southeast Asian nations will be limited. Reactions of the Southeast Asian nations will only be considered to highlight the contrast of Chinese and Japanese soft power tactics.

BODY

This essay will answer the question “**How do China and Japan's soft power strategies in Southeast Asia differ?**” through an analysis of their distinct soft power resources (I) and the unique ways in which they are instrumentalised (II) resulting in diverging soft power strategies of the two countries in Southeast Asia.

I. Existence of Distinct Soft Power Sources

China and Japan’s soft power strategies in Southeast Asia are a direct reflection of both, their resources, and their national goals. As outlined by Hendrik W. Ohnesorge, soft power resources can be of four kinds, of which the two that are intentionally deployed in Chinese and Japanese governmental strategies are Values and Policies.⁹ These also form two of the 3 resources that constitute Joseph Nye’s fundamental soft power triad.¹⁰ A comparison of the countries’ soft power resources reveals an inherent difference in what drives their soft power strategies and

⁷ Sun, Jing, *Japan and China as Charm Rivals: Soft Power in Regional Diplomacy* (University of Michigan, 2012)

⁸ IBID.

⁹ Hendrik W Ohnesorge, *Soft Power – The forces of attraction in international relations* (Basel: Springer International Publishing, 2019)

¹⁰ Culture, Values and Policies; see Nye, Joseph, *Soft Power: The Means To Success In World Politics* (Hachette UK, 2009)

thus explains the fundamental divergence in their policies and implementation, which will be explored in the next section.

Of the two countries, Japanese resources are considered more traditional in their adherence to the soft power categories. Japan's umbrella resource is its overall image being that of a culturally rich and politically peaceful nation, that upholds values of freedom, security and peace. Seen in publications such as its National Security Strategy of December 17, 2013, Japanese claims that it has "contributed to peace, stability and prosperity of the region and the world,"¹¹ help reaffirm the existence of these soft power resources. In the current context of the information age and an increase in surveillance technologies, these values manifest in its governance model, which balances state security with "universal values, such as freedom, democracy, respect for fundamental human rights and the rule of law."¹² This is in stark contrast to the Chinese "surveillance state"¹³, which, with its authoritarian image, is highly unattractive to Southeast Asian countries (with young, aspiring populations) and is therefore counter-productive to any soft power resource. Less typical, yet equally aligned with its humanitarian values, another one of Japan's soft power resources is its military assets. Although theoretically considered a hard power resource, the use of the Japanese Self-Defence Forces (JSDF) for capacity-building and training with smaller Southeast Asian countries, along with the JSDF's large-scale involvement in Humanitarian Assistance and Disaster Relief operations such as in the Philippines in 2013, evidence its presence as a soft power resource. Even Nye concedes that the usefulness of the military as a soft power resource depends on whether it is deployed in assistance mode or coercion mode.¹⁴ As Japanese soft power resources and ideas have existed and developed over centuries, they tend to be conceived in more traditional long-term ways, whereas Chinese conceptions of soft power are driven by resources that can be harnessed to provide short-term results for a rapidly developing nation.

Therefore, in contrast to Japan, China's soft power resources are widely questioned in nature. Lacking in internationally accepted values, China uses its economic prowess as its primary soft power resource. What is most appealing to the smaller, developing Southeast Asian countries is China's success story; its economic growth since the establishment of the PRC in 1949 means

¹¹ "National Security Strategy December 17, 2013 I. Purpose."
<https://www.cas.go.jp/jp/siryoku/131217anzenhoshou/nss-e.pdf>.

¹² IBID.

¹³ "Resolved: Japan Is Well-Positioned to Counterbalance China in Southeast Asia" Center for Strategic and International Studies. <https://www.csis.org/analysis/resolved-japan-well-positioned-counterbalance-china-southeast-asia>.

¹⁴ Nye, Joseph, *Soft Power: The Means To Success In World Politics* (Hachette UK, 2009)

that today it has an economy almost 3 times that of Japan, with much better prospects for future growth. This economic prowess is therefore translated into a soft power resource for China, which uses it as a means to attract Southeast Asian nations into forming trade and investment agreements. This mobilisation of its economic strength as a soft power resource is a trend within Chinese foreign policy globally and can also be seen in other regions such as Central Asia and Africa. Author Ayjaz Wani has claimed that Chinese soft power diplomacy is driven by self-serving hegemonic tendencies, which drive soft power goals on the basis of selfish economic pursuit. This explains how Chinese soft power strategies are framed by the goal of creating a “Sino-Centric Asia”¹⁵ in the hope to obtain enough resources to feed its growing economy.¹⁶ Despite Japan’s own economic resources, such as its funds reserved for Foreign Direct Investments in railways, powerplants, bridges etc, its goals are more focused on creating long-term positive images of itself. It has much less economic potency than China, who uses its economy to conceive of soft power in a much broader way than originally theorised.¹⁷ Appropriately, David Shambaugh, one of the foremost China experts, has claimed that the strongest instrument in Beijing’s soft power toolbox is money.

Hence, it is evident that China and Japan’s soft power resources and goals are fundamentally different, and can be pointed to as the cause for their distinct soft power strategies.

II. Implementation as Diverging Soft Power Strategies

The utilisation of the aforementioned dissimilar soft power resources by the Chinese and Japanese governments leads to their implementation of drastically different soft power strategies vis-à-vis the Southeast Asian nations. Once again referring to the framework set by Hendrik W. Ohnesorge, it can be said that soft power is effected through instruments, which can be either personal or public diplomacy. As a better representation of the strategies of the countries’ governments as a whole, this essay will focus on the conduct of public diplomacy,

¹⁵ “Resolved: Japan Is Well-Positioned to Counterbalance China in Southeast Asia” Center for Strategic and International Studies. <https://www.csis.org/analysis/resolved-japan-well-positioned-counterbalance-china-southeast-asia>.

¹⁶ “(PDF) Resource Use in Growing China - Researchgate.” https://www.researchgate.net/publication/256031006_Resource_Use_in_Growing_China.

¹⁷ Kurlantzick, Joshua, *Charm Offensive: How China’s Soft Power Is Transforming the World* (Yale University Press, 2007)

which can be defined as, “all official efforts to convince targeted sectors of foreign opinion to support or tolerate a government’s strategic objectives.”¹⁸

Japanese public diplomacy rests on the instrumentalization of its resources through establishments such as the Japan Foundation, which is an organisation and separate legal entity responsible for the dissemination of Japanese culture across the world. With multiple exhibitions of Japanese art, classes for Japanese language education and the provision of the Japanese-Language Proficiency Test, the Foundation works to increase Japanese presence and thus soft power in other countries, including those in Southeast Asia. A more recent initiative is the Asia-Japan Investing for the Future Initiative which was launched in January of 2022 to “improve the region’s attractiveness as a hub of global supply chains and create innovations innovation to enhance sustainability and solve social challenges through collaborations between private and public sectors of both Japan and ASEAN.”¹⁹ This economy – oriented approach to soft power diplomacy can be seen as a direct counter to China’s economic policies, although in line with Japanese goals, it still focuses on collaboration between the private sectors of Japan and ASEAN countries in contrast to Chinese economic policies which are more commonly one-way investments by China to projects in Southeast Asian nations. This difference in public diplomacy, driven by their Hegemonic versus Value-based soft power goals, also means that China frames its relationships with smaller Southeast Asian states (those with less global market integration such as Cambodia, Laos and Myanmar) into asymmetric power relationships to maximise its own benefit as opposed to Japan, whose engagement in Southeast Asia is stronger with larger countries (those that have more economic connectivity such as Thailand, Singapore and Indonesia) that allow for mutual growth opportunities. All of this means that Japan is viewed as the region’s most trusted external power²⁰, proving the success of its soft power instrumentalization.

Contrastingly, Chinese public diplomacy can be seen as simply an extension of its economic resources, the instrumentalization of which leads to policies that have been termed “soft economic diplomacy.”²¹ The best example is China’s Belt and Road Initiative (BRI) which, to promote trade and connectivity, forms a series of bilateral agreements facilitating Chinese

¹⁸ <https://www.britannica.com/topic/public-diplomacy>, Encyclopedia Britannica

¹⁹ “Concrete Actions Based on Asia-Japan Investing for the Future Initiative.” ERIA. <https://www.eria.org/events/concrete-actions-based-on-asia-japan-investing-for-the-future-initiative/>.

²⁰ Singapore’s Institute of Southeast Asian Studies. <https://www.iseas.edu.sg/>

²¹ Carminati, Daniele. *The State of China's Soft Power in 2020*. E, 3 July 2020, <https://www.e-ir.info/2020/07/03/the-state-of-chinas-soft-power-in-2020/>.

investment in infrastructural projects and control over the financial integration of partner nations, including those in Southeast Asia.²² This allows China to have direct control over large part of the countries' economies and domestic economic policies. China's ability to influence other states due to its economic abilities is also seen through its "mask diplomacy"; China's funding allowed it to ship numerous medical supplies to struggling countries in the region and gain their favour.²³ These instances are indicative of a developing "soft power with Chinese characteristics"²⁴, often associated with "sharp power."²⁵ In fact it is difficult to disassociate China's cultural instruments from its economic capabilities due to the large number and spread of Confucius Institutes and classes across the globe. However, these can be credited with being more traditional forms of soft power public diplomacy with functions and therefore impacts similar to the Japanese Foundation discussed above. In fact, scholar Rumi Aoyama brings to the forefront China's more nuanced tactics of public diplomacy, which are focused on forming a desirable image of the state. This includes the establishment of both formal and informal summits under Chinese supervision to subtly recognise its major, and perhaps leading, role in the region.

Unfortunately, these attempts at traditional soft power diplomacy have not been enough to overshadow the Chinese attempts at gaining influence in Southeast Asia. Respondents to the [State of Southeast Asia Survey](#)²⁶ (including policymakers, businesspeople, media personnel etc) generally agreed that China's increasing influence in the region is concerning. This is opposed to the conception of Japan, whose attempts at soft power diplomacy are not seen as exploitative. AS journalist and author Sebastian Strangio says, Japan is seen as "large enough to be helpful, yet not so large as to incite fear and anxiety."

Therefore, both China and Japan use public diplomacy as an instrument of soft power, but in distinct ways and with different results.

²²Southeast Asian signatories include Cambodia, Indonesia, Malaysia, Myanmar, Philippines and Singapore. See "Belt and Road Initiative (BRI)." European Bank for Reconstruction and Development (EBRD). <https://www.ebrd.com/what-we-do/belt-and-road/overview.html>.

²³ "Chinese Diplomacy in Southeast Asia during the COVID-19 Pandemic." Asia Society. <https://asiasociety.org/policy-institute/chinese-diplomacy-southeast-asia-during-covid-19-pandemic>.

²⁴ "Soft Power with Chinese Characteristics." Soft Power with Chinese Characteristics | Center for Strategic and International Studies. <https://www.csis.org/analysis/soft-power-chinese-characteristics>.

²⁵ "What Is 'Sharp Power'?" Journal of Democracy. <https://www.journalofdemocracy.org/articles/what-is-sharp-power/>.

²⁶ ISEAS. <https://www.iseas.edu.sg/>

CONCLUSION

In conclusion, it is evident that China and Japan's diverging soft power strategies are a result of their varied soft power sources and their consequent implementation. As each country strives to achieve dominance in Southeast Asia, it instrumentalises its resources in ways that it believes will be most effective in garnering soft power. While Chinese soft power strategies aim for short-term results driven by economic prowess, Japanese strategies rely on long-term value-based trust and relationships. As China begins to rear its head as a significant player in the historically Japanese dominated region, only time will tell which of the two soft power approaches will be successful in generating greater influence.

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APPENDIX

Soft Power - The Forces of Attraction in International Relations, Hendrik W. Ohnesorge

Table 3.2 The four soft power subunits and their respective indicators

Subunit	Component	Indicator(s)
I Resources	(1) Culture	(1) Pervasiveness of (high and popular) culture
	(2) Values	(1) Values represented (2) Consistency of values with political action (3) Commitment to multilateralism
	(3) Policies	(1) Grand strategy (2) Relation to hard and soft power (3) Primacy of national interest vs. common good (4) Adherence to international law (5) Credibility and legitimacy (6) Prevalent domestic policies and issues
	(4) Personalities	(1) Character and charisma of decision-makers (2) Team of cabinet members and advisors (3) Relationships between decision-makers
II Instruments	(1) Public Diplomacy	(1) Overall organizational structure (2) Personnel (leading positions and staff) (3) Budget (4) Particular programs and initiatives
	(2) Personal Diplomacy	(1) Number, duration, and quality of foreign travels (2) Speeches and public remarks (3) Symbolic acts (4) Influential networks
III Reception	Attraction ∨ Apathy ∨ Repulsion	(1) Public opinion polls (2) Contemporary statements and subsequent reminiscences of decision-makers and elites (3) Media and content analysis
IV Outcomes	Compliance ∨ Neutrality ∨ Opposition	(1) Compliance record in international organizations (2) Voting patterns in U.N. General Assembly (3) Compliance in foreign policy decisions (4) Number and character of treaties concluded/joined